

compared to the background. This gave rise to the idea of a three dimensional feel and the rounded-cornered boxes.

While the 3D effect was easily achieved by creating little graphic strips on the GIMP, I was torn between using images or CSS styling to achieve the rounded corner effect. While this could easily be achieved using the CSS styling rule `-moz-border-radius`—this styling is effective only on Mozilla Firefox and other Gecko-based browsers. This meant that the corners stayed rectangular for our visitors on Opera, Chrome, Safari and IE. Initially we had felt that we'd let it stay that way, publicly disclosing that we have made the website look more beautiful only for those with an open source browser (sadly, Chromium was excluded). However, we later changed our stance and decided to transform the edges into images. Although the menu bar would still be rounded only for the Gecko based browsers! :-)

Now that we managed to put the 'theme wars' to rest, we moved on to more serious jobs, i.e., hacking into the core PHP of the theme.

Redesigning the LFY logo

This was the toughest decision for us—redesigning the LFY logo. It takes years, even decades, to build up a brand and win recognition for it. At that point, a decision to revamp the very image that defines a brand can give any CEO a heart attack. So, we were very afraid to experiment with the current design of LFY's logo (Figure 1-a). Thousands of readers around the country have come to associate this logo with our beloved magazine. How do we change all of that, overnight? Yet, there was this burning flame in our hearts to usher in a change, a revolution, and we went about our task.

We started slowly, without trying to be radical. We needed to understand which part of our logo needed more weightage. So, we broke up the logo into three pieces, 'LINUX', 'FOR YOU' and the tag line. Speaking of branding, we were very cautious about the 'FOR YOU' bit, and started getting a bit narcissistic as we went along, paving the way to the

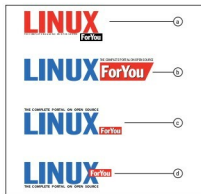


Figure 1: LFY progressive logos

design in Figure 1-b. While we still gave the same importance to 'LINUX', we were quick to realise that the 'FOR YOU' brand still had a long way to go before it earned the right to capture as much screen space as 'LINUX'. So, we reduced the size and formulated the design in Figure 1-c.

I do not know if you'd believe us but this logo actually got us very sad. Why, you might ask. Well, we love Linux and everything to do with it. However, in the logo, the 'FOR YOU' (that symbolises us) seemed to be very disassociated with 'LINUX' and we rejected it immediately.

We went back to the drawing board and started rethinking the role of LFY in our readers' life. We felt, we still exist because we managed to cater news, reviews and resources on Linux and open source to our readers, and this is what makes us survive and also find so much love around. This gave rise to the very wacky idea of us being a courier service that brings 'LINUX' to our readers' homes and hence we got the idea of the courier service's sticker pasted on top of the 'consignment',



Figure 2: Another option, we considered



Figure 3: The final logo

which is 'LINUX'!

So, what do you say? Are we still the age-old magazine house with vanilla mentalities? *We are turning wacky too! :-)*

Feature requirements

1. While we were brainstorming on the feature requirements for LinuxForU.com, there were a lot of debates on how the content ought to be customised. Although I, personally, was in favour of genre-based categorisation, not many felt good about changing the categorisation structure from that of the magazine. While you wish to give your product an image overhaul, it becomes very hard to ignore your legacy and the norms that you have been following all these years. This finally resulted in a compromise—we decided to allow our readers to choose the way they wanted the content to be categorised. This very idea later made me wonder (without being intentionally narcissistic) why didn't other content-based portals all over the Web follow the same pattern?
2. One of our major concerns was the 'Archives' page. Since we plan to put up all the content from our previous issues, online, the content needed to be easily searchable and browse-able by visitors. Moreover, while we *were* building a website, at the end of the day it actually was an extension of the magazine itself. So while we aimed at a revamp, it was also important for us to maintain the feel of a magazine's website.
3. While the existing 'commenting' feature of WordPress is pretty nifty, I always used to search around for Ajax-based commenting. Moreover, I also wanted the comments to be editable by our readers, but only up to 15 minutes of the comment getting published.
4. "Before you expect something from others, always think of how to give out." It was this principle that made us wonder if there could be anything we could give to our readers for commenting on our website. Of course, it always